’Tis New to Thee

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Huxley Returns to the Brave New World.
A Re-creation



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Prologue: The Temptation of Being Right

I died on the 22nd of November 1963, in Los Angeles, on an afternoon when the world had more important things to attend to. In Dallas a President had been shot, and beside such an event the death of an ageing novelist looks much as a falling leaf looks beside an earthquake. I have never held it against the world. On the contrary, I thought it a fitting punchline for a man who had spent half his life asking what human beings pay attention to, and why so rarely to the things that matter.

How I came to return I shall not attempt to explain. The mystics, whose writings I collected in my later years, would have a word for it; the physicists, presumably, a formula. I content myself with observing that I am sitting in an express train somewhere in the middle of Germany, open carriage, second class, and that for the first time since my boyhood I am permitted to see clearly.

That is no small thing. At sixteen I contracted an inflammation of the cornea which left me, for a long time, very nearly blind. I had meant to become a doctor, as befitted a grandson of Thomas Henry Huxley, the man they called Darwin's Bulldog for defending the the-

ory of evolution against the bishops. The illness closed the laboratories to me and left me only the books. So it was that a thwarted naturalist became a novelist who, all his life, regarded his characters as a zoologist regards his specimens; and I fear that some of my readers noticed. I wrote my books with eyes that could make out little more than outlines, with a magnifying glass and patience and a certain fury at the light. There is an irony, which only now can I fully appreciate, in the fact that a half-blind man should have been celebrated for his foresight. Perhaps one sees the future most distinctly when the present is a blur.

So I can see. And this is what I see.

Some sixty people are sitting in this carriage, and almost every one of them holds his head inclined at an angle I had previously observed only in monks at their office. It is the posture of devotion: the neck bowed, the hands before the breast, the eyes lowered upon a small rectangle which, unlike a breviary, is lit from within. The Benedictines prayed seven times a day. These people, it seems to me, never stop. What they are worshipping I cannot make out from my seat; only that it moves quickly and that they push it onwards with their thumbs, as in former times one pushed along the beads of a rosary.

Outside, a landscape is passing for the sight of which a Dutch painter of the seventeenth century would have gone a month without bread and beer. Water meadows in the mist; a heron standing in the shallows with the indifference of an aristocrat; a church tower rising out of the haze like an exclamation mark without a sentence. Nobody looks out. I count: nobody.

In a small book about my experiences with mescalin I once took up a conjecture that went back to Henri Bergson and to a philosopher at Cambridge: that the brain is less an organ of knowledge than an organ of exclusion. A reducing valve, which out of the overwhelming plenitude of what I called *Mind at Large* lets through only the thin trickle we need in order to survive. I wished, in those days, that some means might be found of opening this valve a little, so that a man might see, at least occasionally, what a chair or a fold in a pair of trousers really is. How was I to guess that a second valve would be fitted instead? An external one, portable, with a battery, which filters the already meagre trickle a second time, until nothing is left but what a company on the west coast of America considers suitable for increasing what its engineers call dwell time. All my life I tried to push open the doors of perception. They have been bricked up, a window has been set into the brickwork, and the window has been declared a television.

Opposite me sits a child of perhaps four. In front of it stands a screen on which brightly coloured animals with unnaturally large eyes are hopping about at a speed no creature in all creation has ever attained. The mother beside it is swiping at her own device. I do not reproach her. She looks tired, with that deep, chronic tiredness which sleep no longer cures, and the screen is the cheapest and most patient nursemaid history has ever produced. But I cannot help thinking of the dormitories of my novel, where the children lay while loudspeakers beneath their pillows whispered maxims to them, a hundred and twenty times a night, until they took the truths of the World State for their own thoughts. I had believed it would be necessary to instruct people in their sleep. In that I overestimated them. One can instruct them perfectly well while they are awake, provided one makes sure they do not notice.

I had set my brave new world in the year 632 After Ford, which is to say somewhere in the twenty-sixth century. Six centuries struck me as a reasonable allowance for mankind to ruin itself thoroughly. In 1946, after a war that had taught me better about the speed of human progress in evil, I corrected myself in a foreword to a new edition: it now seemed quite possible, I wrote, that the horror might be upon us within a single century. Eighty years have passed since then. I find

that this estimate, too, was generous, though the horror has come in a shape I did not foresee. There are no hatcheries, no castes decanted from bottles, no World Controller in an office in London. And yet I sit in this carriage with the uneasy feeling of walking through the scenery of a play I wrote myself, except that someone has improved the stage directions.

Then something happens for which I am not prepared.

The young man next to me, an amiable-looking fellow with earphones so small that they look like jewellery, slides his thumb across his device, and for the space of a blink I see my own name. Above it stands a sentence, set against a sunset in that shade of orange which is rare in nature and common on soft-drink cans. I never wrote the sentence. It has been put into my mouth, as the Greeks put a coin into the mouths of their dead so that they could pay the ferryman. Only here it is not the dead man who pays for the crossing but the advertisement that follows immediately: a telephone, thinner than the last one, brighter than the last one, and, as a gentle voice assures me, the best there has ever been. The young man lingers on me for perhaps a second. Then comes a cat.

And at that moment, I confess, it wells up in me.

It is warm, it is sweet, it is almost physical, and it shapes itself into a sentence known to everyone who has ever been right without anyone caring: *I told you so.*

I know this feeling. I have seen it in politicians, in prophets and in writers of letters to the editor, and I know what it is. It is the oldest intoxicant of mankind, older than wine and opium, and unlike these it grows everywhere and costs nothing. A gramme of being right, and every injury is forgotten. My soma, as I assured my readers in the novel, had no side effects. Being right has a single one, but it is devastating: it makes you blind. I know what I am talking about. I have been blind before.

Almost ninety years ago, in a book entitled *Ends and Means*, I tried to show that non-attachment is the heart of every serious ethic: the capacity not to cling, whether to possessions or to fame or to one's own opinions. I wrote that with the dictators of Europe in mind, who clung to their power like flies to a strip of flypaper. I scarcely considered that the ego of the prophet is made of the same stuff as the ego of the tyrant. It merely wants something different. The tyrant wants to be obeyed. The prophet wants to be told, afterwards, that he was right. I do not know which of the two wishes is the more childish.

The Greeks tell of Cassandra, the Trojan princess whom Apollo cursed when she rejected his love: she was always to foretell the truth and never to be believed. A cruel curse, but a transparent one. Cassandra at least knew where she stood, and could rage.

My curse is subtler, and I suspect it is the curse of this entire age. I am believed. People nod. They quote me, sometimes even correctly. They put me on the syllabus, print me on coffee mugs, film me, and discuss me in review sections which are themselves wedged between two advertisements for luxury watches. And then they buy the horse, in twenty-four convenient monthly instalments. A man who is not believed may at least be angry. A man who is believed and changes nothing is not even left that, only the question whether the fault lies with the world or with the way he spoke to it.

It strikes me that in this age everyone keeps a careful ledger of other people's errors. They can be retrieved with a few movements of the finger, dated and timestamped, and people retrieve them with the zeal of an accountant who has caught a colleague embezzling. Nobody keeps a ledger of his own errors. It would presumably be the least popular application imaginable, and the most useful. I resolve to open one before

I reproach anyone with what I foresaw. It will not, I fear, remain empty.

The train slows. A friendly voice apologizes for a delay whose causes nobody wishes to know, and everyone accepts the apology without looking up. A well-bred society, I think. Nobody complains, nobody protests, nobody visibly suffers. Mustapha Mond would have been enchanted.

And that is why I must find out how it was done, without hatcheries, without castes, without a World Controller. For the question is no longer whether my prophecy has come true. The question is why it does not hurt anybody.

I. The Love of Servitude

The station at which I alight is no longer a station but a shopping centre to which, out of politeness, a few platforms have been attached. I walk through an arcade of glass and light, past shops selling things I did not know one needed and which, as the shop windows assure me, one will no longer need tomorrow, because there will be better ones. I order a coffee. The girl behind the counter does not ask whether I will pay in cash but holds out a small screen on which I am invited to choose between three levels of gratuity. The lowest is fifteen per cent. There is also an option for no gratuity at all; it is printed smaller and in grey, like an emergency exit one is not supposed to use. I choose the middle one. I am a polite man, and the machine knows it.

Then, out of pure curiosity, I wish to use the station's free network, of which there is talk everywhere. Before it admits me, it asks me to accept its terms and conditions. I am an old-fashioned man, and I begin to read. After four minutes I have reached clause seven, which governs to whom my data may be passed on, namely to partners whose names are not given, for purposes which are not further specified. The progress bar at the right-hand edge informs me that I have managed about one twentieth. Beside me a man in a suit presses *Ac-*

cept without looking, with the serene matter-of-fact-ness with which, in the Middle Ages, one crossed one-self on entering a church.

In 2008 two American researchers calculated how long an ordinary person would need to read all the privacy policies he agrees to in the course of a year. They arrived at some seventy-six working days. The figure, I imagine, has not grown smaller since. This means that the sentence *I have read and accept the terms and conditions* is the most frequently uttered lie in the history of mankind, more frequent than any marriage vow or oath of office, and it is spoken every day, billions of times over, by people who consider themselves honest and in every other respect are. Nobody requires them to read. They are required only to consent. And because they have consented, nobody can complain afterwards.

I find myself thinking of the dormitories of my novel, and this time with a certain professional envy. My hypnopaedia was crude. It needed loudspeakers and pillows and a hundred and twenty repetitions a night. Here a single button suffices, and the astonishing thing is not that people press it but that, as they do so, they feel they have made a free decision. They have, after all, consented. No tyrant in history ever brought his subjects to the point of putting on their own chains

while signing a form to confirm that they had done so of their own free will.

In 1946 I wrote that a really efficient totalitarian state would be one whose citizens no longer needed to be coerced, because they loved their servitude. At the time I took the sentence for a gloomy flourish. Today it strikes me rather as a sober description of customer service. Someone has grasped what the dictators of my day never grasped: that coercion is expensive. It requires policemen, prisons, informers and camps, and it generates hatred, and hatred is a fuel that sooner or later bursts its own furnace. Convenience, on the other hand, costs almost nothing and generates gratitude. He who coerces people must coerce them afresh every day. He who makes things convenient for them need only accustom them, and habit, as any smoker will confirm, does the rest by itself.

Orwell's torturers had their Room 101, in which every man was confronted with what he most feared. The great invention of our time is, so to speak, Room 101 turned inside out: a room in which every man receives exactly what he most desires, at exactly the moment he desires it, before he even knows that he desires it. Orwell's room broke the will. This one makes it superfluous.

There is a word I have met again and again in these first hours, on posters, in advertisements, on the sleeve of my coffee cup. The word is *seamless*. Everything nowadays is to be seamless: paying, travelling, shopping, working, the connection between the telephone in one's trouser pocket and the watch on one's wrist. I have pondered this word as, when I was young, I pondered words in ancient languages. A seam is the place at which one can tell that a thing has been made. It betrays that two pieces of cloth have been joined here, by a hand, with an intention. A seamless garment seems not sewn but grown, as natural as skin. And therein lies the whole secret. A world without seams is a world in which one no longer sees that it was made, or by whom, or for what. What is seamless can no longer be unpicked. It can only be worn.

In my novel the children learned a little rhyme in their sleep: *Ending is better than mending.* The World State needed consumers who did not repair their things but replaced them; otherwise the factories would have stood idle. I had believed that this lesson would have to be laboriously drummed into people. A more elegant way has been found: things are now built so that they can no longer be mended. The young man's telephone on the train is sealed like a sarcophagus. Whoever opens it forfeits the guarantee, and whoever does not open it forfeits the telephone as soon as the battery

grows tired. The rhyme is no longer necessary. The lesson is in the casing.

And yet even this is not the most refined thing. The most refined thing is the calendar. Every year in the autumn, so I learn from the shop windows, a new model is unveiled, in a ceremony followed by millions of people throughout the world, with a man on a stage who speaks in a devout voice of cameras and processors. I have studied many liturgies in my life, the Catholic, the Buddhist, the Hindu, and I know one when I see it. There is the High Mass in September, the Lent of waiting, the Feast of Delivery and the confessional of the comment sections, where one admits that one could really have kept the old model a little longer. And there is the sin, the only one this church truly recognizes: contentment with what one has.

For this is precisely the point at which my World State and yours resemble each other perfectly. A contented man is, to an economy founded on growth, a nuisance, almost a saboteur. He buys only what he needs, and he needs astonishingly little. He goes for walks without equipment, and he looks out of the train window instead of at a screen. In my novel the children were therefore cured of their love of nature with electric shocks, because country walks cost nothing. Here no electric shocks are needed. Nature has simply been

moved to the edge of the field of vision, where it drifts past like a screensaver, pretty and irrelevant, while in the middle of the field of vision something glows that moves.

It will be objected, and rightly, that all these people act of their own free will. Nobody forces them to buy the new model, nobody forces them to press *Accept*. They could refrain. They are free. I grant it. They may choose between three colours, four storage capacities and two screen sizes. They may choose the device on which they spend their time, and the application. They may choose between forty kinds of yoghurt and sixty series, all released on the same evening. Freedom of choice is more lavish today than ever before in history. Only one choice is missing from the range on offer, and it is the only one that would matter: the choice whether one wishes to choose at all. The freedom to choose between things has not enlarged the freedom to do without them. It has replaced it.

I finish my coffee and notice that it is excellent. I am bound to admit as much, for a prosecutor who suppresses the merits of the accused is not a prosecutor but a man bent on revenge. The world I find here is in many respects more agreeable than the one I left. People are healthier and better fed, they live longer, and hardly one of them ever has to be truly cold or

hungry. A cynic who denies this has understood nothing. But this is what makes the question so difficult to put without seeming ungrateful. It is easy to protest against a dungeon. To protest against a sitting room whose door is not locked, which one simply never leaves because it is colder outside and the coffee inside is so good, is an art for which no textbooks have yet been written.

On my way out I pass the man in the suit once more. He has found the network by now; he is telephoning, laughing, and incidentally ordering something that will be lying on his doorstep in two hours. He does not look unhappy; on the contrary. He looks like a man who is being gently guided through his day by an invisible hand, and is grateful for it.

Which leaves the question of whose hand it is.

II. Who Conditions the Conditioners?

From here on I report from memory. The hours of this age run faster than any pen, and by the first afternoon I had given up trying to keep pace with them.

To find out whose hand it was, I did what a man of my generation does in such cases: I went to a library. It was, to my relief, still there, though curiously quiet, not out of reverence but because most of its visitors were wearing earphones. I sat down at one of the public computers and read. In my youth I had travelled with the Encyclopaedia Britannica in my luggage, in a crate made specially for the purpose, and my friends used to say that one could tell from my conversation at dinner which letter of the alphabet I had reached. The habit has survived death. I returned to that library often in the days that followed, and much of what I have still to report I read there. On that first afternoon, however, I read what the great companies of the present publish about themselves: their annual reports, the transcripts of their conversations with investors, the declarations of their boards.

I had expected to find a secret. I found something more disquieting: there was none.

Everything was there, in plain words, accessible to anyone. They spoke of *engagement*, of *time spent*, of *daily*

active users, and of how they intended to increase these quantities in the coming quarter. They spoke of human attention as the mining companies of my youth had spoken of coal seams: as a deposit to be opened up and extracted, as completely and as cheaply as possible. Nobody disguised it. One had only to read it. And it was here that I understood that, in the matter of concealment, I had thought just as old-fashionedly as Orwell. We had both imagined that the powerful would lock their truths away in safes. They no longer lock them away. They put them into an annual report of two hundred pages, and boredom guards them more reliably than any secret service.

One must not conclude from this that the power expressed in these reports is small or dispersed. It is not. A handful of companies now administer the channels through which a large part of mankind learns what is happening in the world, whom it talks to, what it buys and what it holds to be true. In some of these companies a single man, thanks to an ingenious arrangement of different classes of shares, holds the majority of the votes, so that no shareholder and no board can remove him. In my novel I invented ten World Controllers who ruled the whole planet. At the time I took that for a fantastic exaggeration. I must correct myself: today ten would be almost too many.

As early as 1958 I had written about what I called over--organization: the tendency of modern technology to concentrate economic and political power in fewer and fewer hands, in the great corporations and the great government departments, and to turn the individual into an employee of his own circumstances. I quoted American sociologists at the time who spoke of a power elite and of the organization man, who leaves his personality in the company cloakroom. What I did not foresee is that the organization would one day organize not only the employee but also his evenings, his sleep, his friendships and his mood on waking.

To this extent I grant the suspicion that in the end only a few players sit at the table. But here the real difficulty begins, and it is the reason why I have given this chapter a question for a title rather than an answer.

Mustapha Mond, my Resident Controller for Western Europe, was a man who knew what he was doing. He had been, as he confesses to the Savage, a gifted physicist in his youth, too gifted for the World State, and he had been offered a choice: banishment to an island where the misfits live, or admission to the circle of the rulers. He chose to rule. In his safe he kept the forbidden books, the Bible, Shakespeare, the mystics, and he had read them. He knew exactly what he was withholding from people: truth, beauty, tragedy, God. He

had exchanged all this for happiness, with his eyes open, and he defended the bargain with arguments that I myself found it hard to refute. Mond was a tyrant, but he was a free tyrant. He could have opened the safe at any time.

The masters of this age are, from all I have read, not quite so free. I say *not quite*, for I have no intention of writing them a letter of excuse. But consider the chain.

First there are the engineers who build the machines, young and well-paid, Alphas in the literal sense of my novel. They design the mechanisms that keep people at the screen, and they are measured by how well they succeed, by figures that appear on a board every morning. They are not wicked. Most of them would indignantly deny manipulating anybody. They optimize. Some of those who invented the best known of these mechanisms have since publicly regretted what they created. But regret does not change the metrics, and the metrics decide promotion.

Above them stand the boards, and they in turn are measured by figures, by quarterly reports, by growth, by the share price. A board that resolved henceforth to let its users spend less time on its platforms, because this would be good for their souls, would be punished by the markets before it had finished its sentence. Even those few who, by virtue of their voting rights, cannot

be removed must fear the competition, which will lure attention away the moment they slacken. They sit upon the throne, but the throne stands on a treadmill.

And to whom do the shares belong? Here it becomes truly Huxleyan. To a large extent they belong to enormous funds that manage the money of millions of ordinary savers: teachers, nurses, tradesmen putting something aside for their old age. These funds wield enormous power; they vote at shareholders' meetings, and their concentration is itself a serious problem. But the money with which they vote is the savers' money. The nurse who watches anxiously in the evening as her grandchildren stare at screens for hours is, through her pension, a partner in the very business that worries her. Her pension rises with her grandchildren's screen time.

The ancients had an image for this kind of circle: the ouroboros, the serpent that bites its own tail. The conditioners are conditioned by their metrics, the metrics by the shareholders. And the shareholders? Whoever walks round the circle in search of the culprit arrives back at himself.

But at this point a temptation lies in wait that is as dangerous as its opposite. One might conclude from the image of the serpent that everyone is equally responsible, and therefore no one. That would be wrong. Even an ouroboros has a head, and the head is thicker than

the tail. A man who commands the voting rights of a company with three billion users bears a different responsibility from the nurse with her savings plan. That he too is a prisoner does not make him innocent. On the contrary, it makes him more dangerous. A free tyrant like Mond could change his mind and open the safe. A tyrant who is himself driven by his machine cannot, and, worse still, he can always plead that he cannot.

One observation in that library shook me more than anything else I read there. In a newspaper archive I found several reports that many of the people who invented these devices and platforms carefully keep their own children away from them. They send them to schools where one writes with chalk and builds with wood, and at home they ration screen time with the strictness of a Victorian nanny. In my novel the Alphas took their soma too. Mond himself may have abstained, but he administered nothing to others that he believed to be poison; he believed it to be happiness. Today's Alphas seem in this respect to be wiser than mine, or more honest, or more cynical; I cannot decide which word is the right one. Perhaps all three.

Who, then, conditions the conditioners? The answer I arrive at is uncomfortable, and I have learned to trust uncomfortable answers more than comfortable ones.

There is a power elite; it is small, and it has more power than any ruler in history ever possessed. But it does not sit in a hidden back room pulling strings. It sits in bright offices, publishes its plans in reports that nobody reads, and is itself part of a machine which it steers but cannot stop and does not wish to stop. That is worse than a conspiracy, for a conspiracy can be uncovered. This machine was uncovered long ago. It stands there in the open, and nothing has changed.

When I left the library it had grown dark. I noticed that this answer did not satisfy me, and I noticed why. It was too complicated. It offered no name at which one could point, no face one could hate. A man can bear a great deal, but hardly anything so badly as a wrong without a wrongdoer.

And I sensed that in this age there would be people ready to supply him with one.

III. The Longing for a Villain

I spent the evening in a tavern of the kind to be found in every town in Europe: dark wood, music too loud, beer served too cold. I had made a habit of listening in such places even in my first lifetime, for I have learned more about the state of a society from conversations at the bar than from the leading articles of its newspapers.

Beside me at the bar sat a man of about fifty, well groomed, well read, with alert eyes and that kind of bitterness which only people develop who notice too much. He did not recognize me, but he recognized in me a listener, and he began to talk. What he said was at first astonishingly intelligent. He spoke of the few corporations that administer the world's attention, and of politicians who promise one thing today and the opposite tomorrow without anyone minding. Much of it I could have written myself; some of it I had thought only that afternoon in the library. I nodded.

Then he lowered his voice.

All that, he said, was merely the surface. Behind it stood quite other people, and with a small movement of the chin he indicated that every initiate knew who was meant. He named no names, and he did not need to. I knew that lowered voice. I had heard it in the thirties in the cafés of Paris, Berlin and London, often

from intelligent people, sometimes from friends, and I knew where it leads.

At the table behind us sat a group of younger people, well dressed, well educated, from those professions in which one talks about communication all day long. They were laughing at people they called *Schwurbler*, a German word for those who spout muddled nonsense, and *Aluhüte*, tinfoil hats, and they were telling one another how, during the great plague a few years earlier, they had broken off contact with relatives who had thought the wrong thoughts. They did so with a cheerfulness that made me shiver. For when I turned round and looked at their faces, I noticed something strange. It was the same face as that of my neighbour at the bar. The same little gleam in the eyes, the same relief, the same relish. The one had found his villain in hiding, the others in the aunt who got her news from the wrong channel. The villains were different. The pleasure in them was identical.

I once wrote a whole book about this pleasure, although hardly anyone has read it. It is called *The Devils of Loudun* and tells of a priest named Urbain Grandier, who in 1634 was burned alive in a small French town. He was accused of having bewitched the nuns of a convent. The nuns writhed in convulsions, the exorcists exhibited them before an audience, sightseers

came from far and wide, and in the end a man was burned whose real offence had been to be vain, handsome and unpopular with the powerful. Grandier was certainly no saint. But he had bewitched nobody.

In the epilogue to that book I tried to describe what went on in the people who watched. I called it herd-intoxication. Man, I suggested, suffers from his self, from his isolation, his fear, his smallness, and he persistently seeks ways of transcending himself. There are upward ways: prayer, art, contemplation, love. They are arduous and rare. And there are downward ways, which are convenient and open to all: alcohol, drugs, debauchery and, more effective than all of these together, the crowd. Whoever is absorbed into a crowd that hates in unison loses for a moment the burden of his self. He is no longer alone, no longer small, no longer uncertain. He belongs, and he is right. I called this downward self-transcendence. It feels like elevation, but it leads to the cellar.

In my first lifetime one still had to go to a market square for this intoxication, to a rally, to an execution. Today, I find, one carries the market square in one's pocket. One can join a crowd every evening without leaving the sofa, and one can choose which. The machines of which I spoke in the previous chapter learned long ago what the exorcists of Loudun knew: that noth-

ing holds people so reliably as a common enemy. Outrage is the most profitable raw material in the mining of attention, and it is extracted in both directions, at every table in that tavern.

In 1958 I also concerned myself with the methods that a certain Austrian corporal had openly set out in his book. He held the masses incapable of grasping anything abstract and therefore recommended that propaganda be simple, that it be repeated incessantly, and that it trace all the causes of misery back to a single adversary. He had grasped that people find a complicated truth harder to bear than a simple lie, and above all that a wrong without a wrongdoer is more unbearable than a wrong with one. The Germans of his day had real reasons for their misery: a lost war, a humiliating peace, an inflation that devoured their savings, a world economic crisis. All of this was intricate, abstract and hard to hate. He gave them instead a people they could hate.

Here I should like to tell a story that has always seemed to me the most perfect parable of this mechanism. At the beginning of the twentieth century a document appeared in Russia that purported to contain the secret plans of a Jewish council for the domination of the world, through control of the press, the banks and the governments. These so-called *Protocols of the*

Elders of Zion were translated into dozens of languages and circulated in millions of copies, and Hitler invoked them. In 1921 a correspondent of *The Times* in London showed that they were a forgery, largely copied from a French satire of 1864. And now comes the twist that I would not let any novelist get away with as too heavy-handed: this satire was directed against Napoleon III, a real, visible ruler known by name, and it described how he manipulated the press and public opinion. The forgers took a critique of real power, struck out the powerful man, and put in his place a minority that possessed no such power.

In this single operation lies the whole function of the villain. He diverts the anger that might be directed against real power onto people who do not have it. The most important service a scapegoat performs is not the one he renders his hunters. It is the service he renders those whom he conceals. No board, no World Controller, no dictator could wish for anything better than a population that has already discharged its anger elsewhere.

Someone will say, and with justice, that it must surely be permitted to criticize the powerful, including the government of a state that regards itself as the homeland of the Jews, and including any lobby that seeks favour in a capital city. It is not merely permitted; it is a

duty. Whoever may not do so lives in Orwell's world, not in mine. But between this criticism and the lowered voice at the bar there runs a boundary, and it is easy to recognize if one knows what to look for. Criticism speaks of particular actions by particular people, which can be named, proved and refuted. The lowered voice speaks of a hidden being that stands behind everything and whose very invisibility is the proof of its power. Against the first kind of assertion one can adduce facts. Against the second one cannot, for every fact that contradicts it becomes proof of how well the hidden ones hide. A theory that nothing can refute does not explain the world. It merely explains why its adherent need ask no more questions.

That is why the lowered voice, strange as it may sound, is a form of soma. It soothes. It turns a confusing world into a comprehensible one, a feeling of impotence into a feeling of knowledge. Whoever has found the villain no longer needs to ask himself what share he has in the serpent's circle, with his pension, his telephone, his thumb that swipes onwards every evening. He belongs among those who know. He is no longer a Beta; he is an initiate. And the price he pays for it is a single one, but it is high: he has stopped looking at the world and begun merely to recognize it, according to a pattern settled in advance.

The same holds for the other side, and that is the part the young people at the table behind me would not have wished to hear. The scorn for the *Schwurbler* is also a downward self-transcendence. It too turns an intricate question, namely which measures in a plague are just and proportionate and which are not, into a simple story of the clever and the stupid. It too spares one the trouble of examining one's own errors, for one was, after all, on the right side. One recognizes a herd-intoxication not by what it is directed against but by how it feels. It always feels good. That is its distinguishing mark.

In the late thirties there was a small institution in America called the *Institute for Propaganda Analysis*. It taught teachers and pupils to recognize the devices of persuasion: the labels with which one brands opponents, the glittering generalities, the appeal to what everybody supposedly thinks. It was a modest and very useful thing. When the war came, it was closed. It was felt, as I later wrote, to be inappropriate to dissect the propaganda of one's own side with the same detachment as that of the enemy. This sentence contains everything there is to say about the difficulty of free thought. Everyone is prepared to see through the propaganda of others. His own he takes
for enlightenment.

How, then, does one tell the villain one wishes for from the one who really exists? That night, on the way to my lodgings, I tried to put together a few questions I mean to ask myself in future before I believe an explanation. Does it relieve me? Does it make me part of a superior group? Does it point at people one recognizes by their origins, rather than at actions one can prove? And is there any fact that would make me give it up? If the answers are yes, yes, yes and no, then I have not found the truth but a drug.

I admit that these questions are uncomfortable, and that they make one lonely. Whoever asks them sits neither at the bar nor at the table behind it. He sits alone, and in an age that delivers to everyone his own crowd in his pocket, that is an unusual condition. One might even take him for a tourist attraction.

IV. The Savage as Attraction

The next morning I found myself in a bookshop, and I mean that literally. *Brave New World* lay on a table by the entrance, in a handsome edition with a sticker announcing that the book was required reading in schools and, incidentally, also available as a series. I learned later that an American streaming service had indeed made a series of it some years ago, with beautiful people in white clothes, and had cancelled it after one season because it did not find enough viewers. I confess that this amused me more than it wounded me. A novel about a world that knows only what entertains had been taken off because it did not entertain enough. Mustapha Mond would have approved the decision.

Beside the table stood a shelf of books about attention. It was a long shelf. There were books on how to put one's telephone down, how to learn to read again, how to free oneself from the clutches of the algorithms, how to rediscover boredom. Many of them bore a *Bestseller* sticker, and a friendly young bookseller explained to me that most of them had been great successes on a platform where people make short videos about books. I thanked her and bought none of them. I had the feeling that I already knew the

contents, and the feeling that I knew the distribution channel even better.

There is a scene in my novel that most readers skip, because it comes near the end, when one already wants to know how things turn out. After his conversation with Mond, John the Savage flees civilization and withdraws to an abandoned lighthouse on the coast. He wants to live there alone, grow his vegetables, pray, and scourge himself for the temptations to which he has succumbed. He wants, in a word, to be the opposite of the World State.

Three workmen happen to see him scourging himself. Then come the reporters. Then comes a man named Darwin Bonaparte, a celebrated big-game photographer, who hides in the undergrowth and films the Savage in secret. The film that results is an immense success. It can be seen, heard, smelt and felt in every feely theatre in the world. And then come the crowds. They land with their helicopters all around the lighthouse, hundreds, thousands, to see the Savage, and they chant in chorus that he should take up the whip. In the end he does, in a fit of frenzy, and the crowd falls into an intoxication that ends in one of those mass orgies which my World State knew as a communal celebration. The next morning he is found hanged.

I wrote this scene almost a hundred years ago, and I took it for the bitterest invention in the whole book. I see now that it was the most accurate prophecy I ever achieved. Not the hatcheries, not the soma, not the hypnopaedia. But this: that a perfected society need not forbid its rebels. It films them.

One has only to look around. The face of a revolutionary who wished to fight capitalism with the gun has been printed for decades on T-shirts manufactured in factories of exactly the kind against which he fought. A famous artist who wished to proclaim his contempt for the art market had one of his pictures run through a shredder hidden in the frame at the very moment it was auctioned. The half-destroyed picture was auctioned again a few years later for many times the original price. The protest against the commodity had increased its value. There is no blade so sharp that this age cannot turn it into a capital gain.

And so it is with the warners. I have seen many of them in these days, on the little screens that people in trains and cafés unwittingly showed me. Some warned against the corporations, some against the governments, some against the media, some against those who warned against the media. There were clever ones and foolish ones among them, and some, no doubt, had indeed been proved right on this point or that.

What struck me about all of them was not what they warned against, but how. They warned before an audience, with raised voices, and every few minutes they interrupted their warning to advertise dietary supplements, secure internet connections or a subscription to their own warnings. The *I told you so* that had come over me so warmly on the train is today no longer a feeling. It is a business model.

This is not to mock the warners. Most of them, like my John, did not choose their lighthouse as a stage. They wished to stand up against something and discovered that the only way to be heard was to become part of the programme they had stood up against. He who is silent is overlooked. He who shouts is broadcast. The system does not seem to provide for a third possibility. And so an odd symbiosis arises between the rebel and the machine. The machine needs him, because outrage sells and because a conspicuous rebel gives the audience the pleasant feeling of living in a world where dissent is still possible. And the rebel needs the machine, because it delivers the audience without which he would consider himself ineffectual. Each lives off the other, and each would indignantly deny the dependence.

Here, as I resolved on the train, I must open my own ledger, for I am more deeply entangled in this story than a prophet would like.

The first entry is embarrassing, and that is why it belongs at the beginning. In the years around 1930, when I was writing *Brave New World*, I toyed in newspaper articles with ideas that my novel mocked. I wrote, with the earnestness of a man who considered himself enlightened, about the necessity of state planning and about improving the population through selective breeding. Eugenics was then a fashion among the educated people of my class; my own brother was one of its leading lights, and I was not as immune to it as my readers like to believe. A literary scholar dug up these articles decades after my death and collected them. I am grateful to him, even though I found the reading uncomfortable. A man who invented the hatcheries of the World State did not, for a time, regard them purely as satire. That should make anyone suspicious who considers prophets infallible, the prophet himself included.

The second entry concerns the novel. In the foreword of 1946 I admitted what I consider its gravest defect: I had left the Savage only two possibilities, the insanity of Utopia or the lunacy of the primitive, the comfortable happiness of the World State or the whip in the lighthouse. A third possibility, a life of sanity, did not occur

in my book. I wrote at the time that if I were to write the book again, I would offer it to him. John was not defeated by the World State, but by the fact that he could only be its opposite. Whoever defines himself entirely by what he is against hands the direction of the play to his opponent. The World State did not need to defeat him. It needed only to set up a camera and wait until he did what his hatred dictated.

The third entry is the most painful, and it concerns this book. You are reading these lines, I imagine, on a screen. Perhaps between two messages, perhaps at night when you ought to be asleep. And perhaps, as you read, you feel that sense of well-being one feels when someone puts into words what one has always suspected. I know that sense of well-being, and I must warn you against it, for it is closely related to the feeling on the train. An essay about distraction can itself be a distraction. It becomes one the moment it is read as one watches a film about a savage in a lighthouse: with sympathy, with approval, and without anything changing afterwards.

What, then, remains for the man who does not wish to become an attraction? I thought about it for a long time that morning, and the answer I found is so unspectacular that it could not be shown in any film, which, I believe, speaks in its favour.

Imagine a man who looks at his telephone, the old one that still works, and decides that it is enough for him. He writes no post about it. He makes no video about his renunciation. He joins no movement campaigning against new telephones. He simply does not buy one. What happens? Nothing. There is no news item, no picture, no data record that would mark him as a rebel. He merely disappears from a statistic. The machine cannot broadcast his protest, because there is no protest. He has not contradicted it. He has merely ceased to be interesting to it.

Therein, I believe, lies the secret of the third possibility that I owed the Savage. It is not loud, and it is not silent. A man who lives so may speak, write, contradict; he should even do so. But he does not do it in order to be seen, and he does not measure his effect by the applause. The opposite of a spectator is not a performer. The opposite of a spectator is a man who is doing something else.

The freest actions of this age are those that generate no data. They cannot be filmed, shared or auctioned. A walk without equipment, a conversation without listeners, a glance from a train window at a heron in the mist. They are worth nothing, in the precise sense of the word, and that is why nobody can buy them from you.

When I left the bookshop it was raining lightly. I did not put up an umbrella. I had forgotten what rain feels like, and I wanted to know again, even though nobody would believe me and nobody saw. For that very reason.

V. Soma, Second Edition

In May 1953 I sat in my house in Los Angeles, under the supervision of a young English psychiatrist named Humphry Osmond, and swallowed a small quantity of mescalin dissolved in a glass of water. I did it as an experiment, with the curiosity of a man who had written all his life about the limits of perception and now wished to know whether they could be moved. What I experienced in the hours that followed I described in a slender book. The flowers in a vase on my desk, which I had scarcely noticed that morning, became a miracle. The folds of my grey flannel trousers became a labyrinth of unfathomable significance. I saw, so I believed, what Adam may have seen on the morning of his creation. I found a word for this state in Meister Eckhart, the German mystic: *Istigkeit*, Is-ness. Things were no longer useful or useless, beautiful or ugly. They simply were, and their being was enough.

In my new life, in a hotel room with a bed that was wider than it was long and a window that would not open, I decided to undertake a second experiment. I considered it no less scientific than the first, if less disreputable. That afternoon I had borrowed one of those telephones; I took it to bed with me and opened one of the applications I had seen so much of in trains and cafés, one of those that show you short films, one after

another, without end. I resolved to observe for one hour what happened to me, as conscientiously as I had done in 1953. On the bedside table lay a notepad.

Of my first experiment a tape recording exists on which I talk for hours about flowers and chair legs. Of this second one I found at the end three words on the pad, in a handwriting I scarcely recognized as mine: *Cat. Politician. Why?* That was not because I had experienced nothing, but because I did not know what. There had been a succession of animals, accidents, recipes, young women dancing, young men complaining about the young women, a politician saying something outrageous, a commentator growing indignant about it, and another commentator growing indignant about the first. I had laughed, been outraged, been moved and been bored, all within a few minutes and several times over. When I looked at the clock, not one hour had passed but almost two. I would have sworn it had been twenty minutes.

Both experiments, then, alter time. That is their first and most conspicuous common feature. But they alter it in opposite directions. Under mescalin every second expanded into a small eternity, and I have retained more of those hours than of some whole years. Under the telephone two hours shrank to a moment, and I retained nothing of them but a faint nausea and the wish

to go on. The one experience filled time, the other emptied it. I do not know which of the two one ought to call a drug, but I know which I consider the more dangerous.

In my novel I had Mustapha Mond praise soma as possessing all the advantages of Christianity and alcohol and none of their defects. It made one cheerful without a hangover, calm without remorse, and it sent people on little holidays from reality from which they returned refreshed. The children learned a rhyme about it in their sleep: a gramme is better than a damn. I had imagined soma as the perfect drug, and I had wondered how such a substance could ever be found.

I was mistaken, and on a point that became suddenly clear to me that night in the hotel room. Soma has not been found as a substance. It has been built as a procedure. And it has been built, and this is the decisive difference, so that it does not satisfy.

One must picture this clearly. Mustapha Mond wanted his citizens to be happy. He was a tyrant, but a well-meaning one, and soma was the instrument of his benevolence: it ended suffering. The machines of this age do not want their users to be happy. They want them to come back. A happy man puts the telephone down, for happiness is a state of satiety, and whoever is full stops eating. A procedure that earns money from

every minute spent with it must therefore never satiate. It must constantly renew the hunger, appeasing it just enough that one does not leave and just little enough that one stays. The old soma was a sedative. The new one is an appetizer.

The psychologists of my day already knew from their laboratories the mechanism on which this procedure rests. An American named Skinner had discovered that pigeons and rats press a lever most persistently when the reward comes not every time but irregularly, unpredictably, sometimes after the third press and sometimes after the thirtieth. On this principle rest the slot machines in the casinos of Las Vegas, whose designers, as an anthropologist later showed in a thorough study, tune their devices with great care to put the players into a trance-like state which the players themselves call *the zone*. In it one forgets time, money, one's own body. One no longer plays in order to win, but in order to go on playing. I recognized this state. I had experienced it for two hours in the hotel bed, with my thumb on the lever.

In 1958 I wrote that the champions of civil liberty, for all their vigilance against censorship, had failed to take one thing into account: man's almost infinite appetite for distractions. At the time I took this sentence for an

observation. I see now that it was a business idea, and that someone has put it into practice.

What is the consequence? The learned are quarrelling about it with a ferocity that reminds me of the stories my family used to tell about the battles over Darwin. In many rich countries, for a good decade now, markedly more young people have been complaining of anxiety, depression and loneliness than before, and this increase coincides roughly with the spread of those telephones. An American psychologist considers the telephones the main cause. His opponents point out that two things growing at the same time are not thereby cause and effect, any more than the stork brings babies merely because there are more of both in the countryside, and they name other reasons: economic insecurity, a plague, news that seems to consist of nothing but catastrophes. I cannot settle this dispute. But I can record what strikes me as a novelist: my World State, for all its cruelty, was a world of contented people. This one is a world of the restless. The distraction I predicted has come; the contentment I had assumed would be its reward has not. They pay the price and do not receive the goods. That, when I think about it, is the most exasperating form of servitude.

Where chemical remedies in the narrower sense are concerned, a distinction is needed that is easily lost in

today's debates: there are medicines that heal and medicines that adapt. Whoever tries to talk a severely depressed person out of his medication from some romantic contempt for pharmacy knows nothing of suffering. Soma begins only where a remedy is no longer meant to make a person well, but to accustom him to circumstances that make him ill. Exactly where this boundary runs is decided not by an essayist but by the patient with his doctor.

In America, where I spent the last twenty-six years of my life, this boundary was crossed in a horrifying way. A pharmaceutical company marketed a powerful painkiller there with the claim that it was scarcely addictive, and encouraged doctors to prescribe it generously. From this lie arose an epidemic of addiction that led on to ever stronger substances, and in the worst years more than a hundred thousand people a year died there of overdoses.

And now, since I promised to be honest, I must speak of my own drug, for here my story becomes most entangled. I did not stop after my experiment with mescalin. Later I took LSD as well, several times, and when I lay dying in November 1963, unable to speak, I wrote on a slip of paper asking my wife Laura to give me some. She did. I died, as they say, under the influence, and I do not regret it.

People will ask how these things go together: the man who warned against soma and the man who asks for LSD on his deathbed. The answer lies in a distinction I worked out in my last novel, *Island*. There is a drug there which the inhabitants of the island call *moksha*, after the Sanskrit word for liberation. It is not taken daily and not as an escape, but rarely, at solemn moments, under guidance, as an aid to perception. Soma closes the doors of perception, moksha opens them. Soma distracts from reality, moksha directs one towards it. It is not the chemistry that makes the difference. It is the direction.

Let me add, however, and it is an entry for my ledger, that the power of these substances is easily overestimated, and that at times I overestimated it myself. Yet even at the end of *The Doors of Perception* I wrote that the experience mescalin bestows is a *gratuitous grace*: neither necessary nor sufficient for what really matters. It can show one that the door exists. One must go through it by other means, through attention, through practice, through a life that is not constantly running away from itself.

I learn, with a mixture of satisfaction and unease, that the substances I experimented with are once again being seriously investigated, that doctors are trying to treat severe depression and old wounds of the soul

with them, and that some countries have already approved them for such treatments. I consider this progress, provided it is done with the care such substances demand. But I also learn that young men in the companies of the American west coast take tiny quantities of them in order to be more creative and productive at the office in the morning. Here I have to laugh, and it is not a cheerful laugh. They have taken moksha, the drug of liberation, and turned it into a means of raising productivity. They have used the instrument that was meant to open the doors to make the machine behind them run faster. Nothing proves the power of this age so much as its capacity to turn even enlightenment into soma.

Towards morning I put the borrowed telephone into the drawer of the bedside table and pushed it shut. Then I did something I had not done since my arrival. I sat down at the window that would not open and looked out. There was nothing special to see: a back yard, a refuse container, a pigeon on a ledge, the dawn slowly lightening the grey of the façades. I had taken no mescalin and no moksha. But I looked for a while without wanting anything, and after a quarter of an hour the pigeon began to *be*, in that quiet, unobtrusive way that Meister Eckhart called *Istigkeit*. Not as strongly as that time in Los Angeles. But it was there, and it cost nothing.

I understood that the question I had asked myself all my life had been wrongly put. I had asked by what means one opens the doors of perception. The answer is: by no means at all, but by a renunciation. One need only stop slamming the doors shut all the time.

VI. The Right to Be Unhappy

The cemetery lay only a few streets from my hotel, and I went there in the afternoon because I was looking for a place where nobody wanted anything of me. I found it. Cemeteries are, it seems to me, the last public spaces of this age in which no screen solicits one's attention. Even here, however, progress had left a small footprint: on some of the newer gravestones I found, beside the names and dates, a little black-and-white square engraved in the stone, and a sign explained that one could photograph it with one's telephone to call up pictures and memories of the deceased. I refrained. The dead, I felt, had a right not to be online any more.

On a bench before a fresh grave sat an old woman. She was sitting there when I came, and she was still sitting there when I passed by again an hour later on my way back. She had no telephone in her hand. She was not reading, not visibly praying, not photographing anything. She simply sat there and looked at the stone. I had seen a great many people in these days, but I think she was the first who was entirely present.

I sat down at the other end of the bench, and after a while we fell into conversation, as one does in cemeteries, slowly and without preamble. Her husband had died in the spring, after fifty-three years of marriage. Her children, she told me, were worried about her. They

had installed an application on her telephone that was supposed to help with grief, with exercises and a mood diary, and they had advised her to talk to her doctor about something to calm her. She knew they meant well. Then she said a sentence I shall not forget: 'I don't even want to feel better. I want to be allowed to miss him.'

In my novel I put into the mouth of one character a demand that I consider the most important in the book, and I found it again on that bench, uttered by a widow who has never read it.

In the penultimate chapter the Savage and Mustapha Mond hold their long conversation about happiness. Mond patiently explains why the World State has banned Shakespeare. Not because Shakespeare is dangerous, but because nobody would understand him any more. Tragedy, Mond says, presupposes a world that is unstable, in which people suffer, love, grow jealous, grow old and die, in which something is at stake. A stable world has no use for *Othello*. High art has been exchanged for happiness, and Mond considers it a good bargain. The Savage objects. He does not want comfort, he says. He wants God, poetry, real danger, freedom, goodness, and sin. Mond replies drily that he is claiming, then, the right to be unhappy. And then he lists what belongs to that right: to grow old and ugly, to

be ill, to have too little to eat, to live in constant fear of what may happen tomorrow, and to be tormented by unspeakable pains. There is a long pause. Then the Savage says that he claims them all.

The right to be unhappy, however, is not the duty to suffer. As a younger man I wrote a rather venomous essay against Pascal, because he sanctified suffering and distrusted joy, and my Savage with his whip was meant as a warning, not as a model. Self-mortification is merely the soma of the severe. Whoever is in pain should have relief, and whoever is ill in mind, treatment. What is at stake is subtler: the freedom to let a feeling that belongs to life run its full course, without its being treated at once as a malfunction.

I knew more of these feelings than my readers may suppose. My mother died when I was fourteen. My brother Trevenen, the person to whom I was closest in my youth, took his own life a few years later. At sixteen I went almost blind. My first wife Maria died of cancer in 1955, and I sat with her and spoke softly to her as she went. Six years later my house burned down in one of the great fires that sweep through the hills of Los Angeles, and with it my library, my manuscripts, my letters and Maria's diaries. I stood before the ashes feeling that I was now a man without a past. I say this not to arouse pity but to explain that I do not speak of un-

happiness as a theorist. I sought none of it, and I would gladly have been spared all of it. But I know that without these losses I would not have become the man I was, and that every book I wrote that is worth anything grew out of one of them.

There was one man who understood this sooner than I did. David Herbert Lawrence, the writer, was my closest friend in the late twenties, and he never tired of telling me that I lived too much in my head. Today I would put it like this: I regarded life as a traveller regards the landscape through the window of a moving train, with great interest and without getting his feet wet. I portrayed Lawrence in one of my novels and, not without self-irony, myself alongside him. When he died of consumption in the south of France in 1930, Maria and I were sitting at his bedside. All my life the critics called me a brilliant intellect without a heart, and they were not entirely wrong. What heart I later possessed I did not think up. I suffered my way to it.

The widow on the bench understood this without my having to explain it. Her children probably did not, and I do not reproach them for it, for they grew up in a time that has taught them something curious.

To explain it, I need a distinction which has grown clearer to me in these days and which I consider the

key to everything I have so far described. It is the distinction between discontent and unhappiness.

Discontent is the feeling that one lacks something one could have. It is directed at the next thing: the new telephone, the better flat, the bigger holiday, the promotion, the partner who would suit one better than the present one. It is small, restless and inexhaustible, and one can appease it, at least for a moment, by a purchase. Unhappiness, by contrast, is the feeling that one lacks something one cannot get back. It is directed at what is lost, at the irretrievable: someone dead, a youth gone by, a love that was not returned, a guilt that cannot be made good. It is large, quiet and heavy, and no shop in the world stocks anything that relieves it.

And now the curious thing: this age is rich in discontent and poor in unhappiness. It produces the one in abundance and carefully keeps the other at a distance. That is no accident. Discontent is the fuel of the machine I described in the preceding chapters. It drives the thumb to the next picture and the hand to the next purchase. A man who is annoyed about the price of the newest telephone is discontented, and that puts him exactly where he is wanted: he argues about the price, not about the point. Unhappiness, however, is dangerous to the machine. A man who truly grieves does not want to buy anything. He does not want to be enter-

tained. He sits for an hour on a bench looking at a stone, and in that hour he asks questions no algorithm can answer: what one lives for, what remains, what one ought to have done differently. Out of such questions religions, philosophies, revolutions and great art arise. No wonder they are not welcome.

Consider how much today serves to abolish the irrevocable. Every order can be returned within thirty days. Every message can be deleted, every mistake undone with a keystroke, every membership cancelled, every person who does not suit one removed from one's life with a movement of the finger and replaced by another, who stands ready in an endless row of faces. In my World State it was said that everyone belongs to everyone else. In this one everyone belongs to everyone else, until the next swipe. Shakespeare could not have written a single tragedy in such a world. *Romeo and Juliet* presupposes that for Romeo there is only one Juliet. *King Lear* presupposes that a kingdom given away cannot be reclaimed. Tragedy lives on the irrevocable. Where everything can be undone, nothing has weight any longer.

Ageing and death, too, have been, if not abolished, then at least cleared out of sight. In my novel people remained physically young until their sixtieth year and then died quickly, in bright hospitals, surrounded by

music and soma. The children were taken to these hospitals for the dying and given sweets there, so that they would associate death with something pleasant. Today I see on the screens faces that are smoothed by little programs before they are shown to others, so that hardly anyone still looks the way he looks. I read of rich men who spend millions on not ageing and who have made the motto *Don't die* into a kind of movement. I understand the wish. I had cancer myself, and I did not enjoy suffering. But I wonder what becomes of a culture that no longer regards death as a teacher but only as a technical problem. All the great wisdom traditions I collected in my book *The Perennial Philosophy* begin with the same insight: that man is mortal, and that he takes his life seriously only once he has grasped this. A man who believes he has an infinite amount of time can afford to waste it. Perhaps it is no accident that he does.

Walter Benjamin, a German writer whom I did not read in my lifetime, died in 1940 on the Spanish border, fleeing from the Nazis. At that time I was sitting in the mild light of California, where I had gone three years earlier, not as a refugee but as a guest, and some of my compatriots never forgave me that comfort. It is a peculiar justice that the man who had to flee wrote more wisely about boredom than the man who was at leisure to be bored. Benjamin wrote that boredom is the dream bird

that hatches the egg of experience, and he meant that the stories a person can tell arise from the empty, slow hours in which nothing happens and one does nothing. I would add that the same is true of grief, of longing, and of every kind of unhappiness that is not immediately anaesthetized. They are the brooding season of the soul. An age that fills every empty hour, drives away every boredom with a picture and treats every grief with an application takes the nest away from the bird. No more eggs are laid. Only content.

When I took my leave of the widow, she asked me whether I too had someone in this cemetery. I said no, not here. She nodded, as if she knew what I meant, and said that I had simply come, then, for no particular reason. I said yes, for no particular reason. That seemed to please her.

On the way to the gate I thought of Mond and the Savage and of the long pause between them. I had written that pause without quite knowing what happens in it. Now I believe I know. In it a man decides to live wholly rather than comfortably. It is a decision one cannot make once and for all, but must make again and again, on every bench, before every stone, with every telephone that begins to vibrate in one's pocket.

The widow had made it. I hoped her children would allow her to.

Epilogue: Achtung

Towards the end of my life I wrote one more novel, which hardly anyone knows, although I consider it my most important book. It is called *Island*, and it is the counterpart to *Brave New World*: the attempt, after thirty years of warnings, to describe for once how things might be otherwise. The critics found it dull. I do not hold it against them. In literature the good is always harder to portray than the evil, and a society in which people deal sensibly with one another offers less material for suspense than one in which they are bred in bottles. That my best-known book is a warning and my least known a hope perhaps says more about the reading public than about the author. Perhaps it also says something about the author.

Island is set on an imaginary island in the Indian Ocean called Pala. A cynical English journalist named Will Farnaby is shipwrecked there, in the service of an oil magnate who covets the island's mineral wealth. He finds a society that has been trying for a century to combine the best of East and West: the science of Europe with the contemplation of Buddhism, medicine with meditation, technical progress with the refusal to be ruled by it. The children there learn not only reading and arithmetic but also how to observe their own feelings without being swept away by them. The families

are open, so that every child has several houses in which to take refuge if it is unhappy in one. And everywhere on the island, in the trees and on the roofs, sit mynah birds that have been trained to call out a single word. The word is *Attention*. And sometimes they add: *Here and now*.

I invented these birds because, after a lifetime of study in mysticism, psychology and pharmacology, I had come to the conclusion that all the wisdom in the world shrinks in the end to this one injunction. The mystics of Christianity, the teachers of Buddhism, the sages of the Upanishads, however different their words, all said essentially the same thing: Be awake. Look. Be where you are. All human misery, so they teach on Pala, begins with a man's not being where he is, but in tomorrow's worries, yesterday's grievances, his fantasies about another life. The birds were to call him back.

At this point I ought to report how the book ends, for it is not a happy ending, and I believe that is precisely what makes it true. Pala perishes. The neighbouring state, ruled by a colonel who considers himself a modernizer, invades in a single night, with the help of a young heir to the throne who dreams of motorcycles and progress, and in the interest of that very oil magnate on whose behalf Will Farnaby had come in the

first place. The armoured cars roll through the villages, and the most reasonable society I ever invented is extinguished in a few hours. Pala was not refuted. It was occupied, for the sake of the oil.

I had written this ending because I knew that reality would write it so. Whoever has the power I described in the second chapter is not to be stopped by reason. So let us not deceive ourselves. The freedom of the individual that I have described in this essay, the glance from the train window, the old telephone one can keep, the hour on the cemetery bench, will break up no corporations and stop no armoured cars. For that one needs laws, courts, elections, newspapers that do their work, and citizens who concern themselves with all of these. Whoever believes the world can be saved by meditation alone has understood as little of the world as someone who believes he can save himself by politics alone.

And yet: Pala perishes, but the birds fly on. That is the last image I left the world, and I consider it truer today than ever. A society can be occupied. A man's attention cannot. It is the only possession that cannot be taken from a man so long as he does not give it up himself. And that is why it is the raw material around which everything in this age revolves. The oil magnates of our day no longer drill for oil beneath other people's

islands. They drill for attention in other people's heads. The difference is that the inhabitants of Pala did not surrender their oil willingly. We surrender our attention willingly every day, minute by minute, swipe by swipe, and call it leisure.

In the prologue of this essay I confessed that on my return I was overcome by the temptation to say *I told you so*. I have kept a ledger since then, as I resolved to do, and I should now like to close it. On one side stand the things I foresaw correctly: the love of servitude, rule by pleasure instead of by coercion, the infinite appetite for distraction, the disappearance of unhappiness and the transformation of the rebel into an attraction. On the other side stand my errors: the span of time, which I measured far too generously; the contentment I promised people as the wage of their servitude, which they have not received; the freedom I ascribed to the rulers, which they do not possess; the eugenic dabblings of my younger years, of which I am ashamed; and my underestimation of the art with which this age turns even its critics into customers, myself included. I have compared the two sides for a long time. I believe they balance.

A prophet whose ledger balances is no longer a prophet. He is a witness. And a witness has no right to cry *I told you so*. He has only the right to report what he has

seen, and then to be silent, so that others can look for themselves.

On the last morning of my visit I sat in a train again. Again the heads were bowed, again the thumbs pushed onwards, again a landscape passed outside that nobody looked at. Opposite me sat a young mother with her daughter, a girl of five or six, who had a picture book on her knees but was not reading it; she was looking out of the window. Suddenly the girl pressed her nose to the glass and cried: ‘Mummy, look! There’s a bird standing in the water!’

It was a heron. Perhaps the same one I had seen on the first day, perhaps another. It stood in the mist above a ditch, motionless, with the indifference of an aristocrat.

The mother looked up. She looked at the heron for three seconds, perhaps four, and for those three seconds there lay on her face an expression I had seldom seen in these days: not entertainment, not outrage, not desire, but simple, quiet wonder. Then she said, ‘Yes, lovely,’ and looked back at her telephone.

Three seconds are not much. No metric captures them. But I have written about people all my life, and I know that sometimes it takes no more than three seconds to remember that there is a world which does not take place on a screen. The birds of Pala were

trained. This child was not. She had simply looked and called out. Perhaps a child is the last mynah bird this age has left. We should pay attention to these birds while they are still calling.

Towards the end of my first life I once said that it was a little embarrassing to have been concerned with the human problem all one's life and to find at the end that one had no better advice to offer than this: try to be a little kinder. I said it at the time with a certain regret, as an admission that my grand theories had shrunk to something very small. For a man who had been called an intellect without a heart, it was a strange testament. Lawrence would have laughed, and he would have been right. I see today that no regret is needed. Kindness is the exact opposite of herd-intoxication. It needs no villain, no crowd and no audience. It cannot be broadcast and it cannot be auctioned. It happens only here and now, between two people, and it presupposes that one sees the other at all.

The German language, among whose speakers I spent these days, possesses a word for which I envy it, because it contains everything I have tried to say. English readers know it chiefly from war films, barked by sentries. The word is *Achtung*. It is the cry of the warner who shouts at a danger. It is the call of the birds of Pala, urging us to attention. And it means re-

spect: what one human being owes another when he treats him not as a customer, not as an opponent and not as a spectator, but as a human being.

I came back intending to greet my contemporaries with the first of these three calls. I leave with the second and the third.

Achtung. Here and now.

About Aldous Huxley

Aldous Leonard Huxley was born on 26 July 1894 in Godalming, Surrey, a grandson of the biologist Thomas Henry Huxley and a great-nephew of the poet Matthew Arnold. At sixteen an eye disease put an end to his plan of becoming a doctor. He read English literature at Oxford and in the 1920s made his name with sharp-witted novels of society such as *Point Counter Point*. *Brave New World* appeared in 1932. Five years later he moved to California, wrote for Hollywood among other things, and turned increasingly to pacifism, mysticism and the exploration of consciousness, as in *The Perennial Philosophy* (1945) and *The Doors of Perception* (1954). With *Island* (1962) he published his counter-utopia to *Brave New World*. He was nominated several times for the Nobel Prize in Literature and died on 22 November 1963 in Los Angeles.

> *'Experience is not what happens to a man; it is what a man does with what happens to him.'*
>
> — Aldous Huxley, *Texts and Pretexts*, 1932

Huxley's return in this essay is fictional. The details of his life and work, and the references to his writings, follow the historical record. Concept, selection and editing: Essah. Written in dialogue with Claude, an AI made by Anthropic. Huxley would have appreciated the irony.



Translated from the German original
Dir ist sie neu

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